

Quod Libet

McGlinn remembered as author, professor, and friend

The Hawk would like to invite the Saint Joseph's University community to participate in a new weekly guest column: Quod Libet. This Latin phrase literally translates as "whatever." The first Jesuits studied at the University of Paris where "quodlibetal" disputation was a common form of engagement in the academic community. In these sessions, any student or teacher could present a topic for discussion, and a battle of points and counterpoints would ensue until a greater resolution could be reached.

That is precisely the goal of this column. As a student, it will serve as your place to call attention to issues that you, as a unique individual receiving a Jesuit education, want to talk about. Every day, we are asked to reconcile our values with the standards of the religious education we are receiving. How is your experience with this balance unique?

Quod Libet is your forum for discussion. Use it to tell your story and pose questions to the community at large regarding your life as a student here. As a member of the faculty or administration, Quod Libet is your chance to engage students. What issues do you wish students were more aware of? What are your suggestions for getting the most out of our experience here? In addition to composing your own editorials, we hope that you will feel compelled to engage those who contribute in discussion.

"Quod Libet" can also describe music involving several different melodies that are counter to one another, but create a unified piece. In the same way, we hope to create a forum that allows all voices to be heard, but contributes to an overall tenor of acceptance and understanding.

This letter is dedicated to the life of the late Marguerite McGlinn, wife, mother, teacher, storyteller, lover-of-all-things-Irish, literati, friend, and mentor.

I remember getting home from work one night in late May and following my usual e-mail-checking routine. This time, though, something was different. As I scrolled down the page, my eyes halted on Professor McGlinn's name. It was a kind of surreal, yet deeply affecting feeling that possessed me with the knowing that this woman, who I had had for two English classes and had been meeting with regularly just a semester prior, was no longer alive. She died of pancreatic cancer on a Monday in May.

As I read the caption on MySJU, an association with the late professor quickly crystallized in my mind. The moment conjured up a short story Professor McGlinn had taught and lectured on, about a boy who deals with death for the first time. As it turns out, that story was "The Sisters" from *The Dubliners*, a collection of short stories by James Joyce.

I can't explain why this association struck me and lingered in my mind for a long

time afterwards, but I decided then that I wanted to write something for this person who had made a special impression on my life. In a way, as I'm writing this, I feel like the boy from "The Sisters" who walks "on tip-toe" into the room where his friend and mentor has been laid to rest.

McGlinn was a part-time professor of English. I was lucky enough to be enrolled into two of her introductory classes in back-to-back semesters during my freshman year.

In high school, I had a teacher similar to her. Both she and McGlinn were Irish-American. Both were around the same age. And both shared a zeal for literature and an appreciation of the word-magic practiced by Joyce, Shakespeare, and others.

I remember listening to Professor McGlinn's lectures and watching her work herself into a kind of intense intellectual frenzy as she discussed the works of great authors. At times, her passion on a subject would cause her to become visibly agitated and some students felt confused at these moments, though I felt closer to her soul.

I do not doubt that her writ-

ing produced a similarly intoxicating effect for her. A graduate from Immaculata University with a Masters from Villanova, McGlinn possessed a rich and substantial academic background which no doubt contributed to her strength both as a teacher and a writer. She taught English at Mount Saint Joseph's Academy in Chestnut Hill for many years before attaining her assistant professorship at St. Joseph's.

McGlinn was the author of several short stories, an edition of Sister Miriam Joseph's *The Trivium*, and was working on a novel titled "The Murder in Yeats Tower" before and presumably at the time of her death.

I remember how she seemed to radiate with enthusiasm and pride as she read an excerpt from her novel to students who stayed after class to hear it. Her detailed descriptions of a mysterious castle set the tone for an intriguing mystery-thriller and it was obvious that she had thoroughly researched her subject. McGlinn's name will forever be linked with her published works that preserve and sustain her creative essence even now.

While she met with me to

work on a personal narrative that I was submitting to the *Crimson & Gray*, she gave me a copy of her short story, "The Sphinx" to help me get some idea of story structure. Her work is a beautiful example of the short story genre. It is dotted with precious poetic morsels such as this: "A hot and bitter jealousy mixed into the boiling cauldron of unrequited love, but I had no choice, I had to join in..."

McGlinn's Irish-Catholic roots weave in and out of this tale, which is set at a Catholic school called "Our Lady of Angels." The main character is a beautiful and virtuous schoolgirl who finds herself conflicted by the attentions she receives from her physical attractiveness and by her own, deeply-felt religious leanings.

McGlinn's passion for all things Irish finds a suitable outlet in her travel, articles which chronicle her explorations of the west coast of Ireland and the scenery of Connemara and County Claire. Her family is from an area near Galway and she made frequent visits there throughout her lifetime.

In "Embracing a Land's Heart of Stone," a travel article which appeared in the LA

Times, McGlinn relates the details of a trip she made with her husband Tom to the Burren, a 100-square-mile landscape in County Clare, Ireland. Her words illustrate an impressive and mysterious place steeped in local history and beautified by exotic flowers, lush peat patches, and monumental footprints from prehistoric history.

McGlinn is survived by three children, a husband, and a host of friends and associates. She has passed "boldly into that other world, in the full glory of some passion," as Joyce said.

I think back to when she appeared physically agitated by the tremendous amount of passion she was experiencing during a lecture and when I read her works now, I sense her presence acutely like something unrestrained and soaring, phoenix-like, in a beautiful Celtic setting within the larger Poet-soul of the Irish.

Thank you for everything Professor. Your memory lives on through your students and all the people whose hearts and minds you have touched.

Michael Stirm '09

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Palin and rising populism reveal deeper problems in American politics

To the Editor:

Sarah Palin is not a smart woman. Her answers in interviews and debates are vague, evasive, rhetorical, and provide no evidence of her understanding of the issues. She thinks living near Russia gives her foreign policy experience. She thinks pregnant rape victims should be forced to give birth. She thinks creationism is a valid argument. She shoots animals from helicopters for fun. She was once blessed to be protected from witchcraft.

Such characteristics might make Palin unique, suitable for local or, perhaps, state government. She seems to be a warm, popular person. But her recent criticism of Barack Obama—claiming that he favored "ambition over country"—perfectly describes Palin's own situation.

She has placed her career and her political agenda over the well-being of America.

Listing Palin's beliefs is like writing a manifesto on neo-conservative idiocy. She thinks being a hockey mom and relating to the average American will qualify her to manage the economy, orchestrate wars, and negotiate with foreign leaders. She does not support gay rights, although she boasts that she has gay friends—as if that makes any difference. She thinks forcing two teenagers into marriage is a testament to family values. She could not name a Supreme Court ruling other than *Roe vs. Wade*. She wants to send U.S. soldiers "out on a task that is from God." She thinks we may need to go to war with Russia, even though it would likely necessitate a mandatory draft. She questions whether global

warming is man-made, but thinks this distinction is unimportant. Essentially, Palin represents everything that a leader of America should not be.

The idea of her running the country is absurd and frightening. John McCain could have picked Joe Lieberman, an intelligent and coherent independent. As the vice-presidential pick, Lieberman would have offered a uniquely bi-partisan ticket which would have, indeed, been "maverick".

It seems, however, that appearances trump capability in this campaign. Lieberman, to be frank, is a boring old white guy. Palin is a young, spirited woman. McCain hoped to attract the female voters who were increasingly losing confidence in Obama; he sought to appeal to the Evangelicals who doubted his commitment to

social conservatism. In the process, McCain also ruined his campaign.

Just when it seemed the GOP had nominated a freethinking intellectual, in came Sarah Palin. Intelligent McCain supporters this November will enter the voting booth murmuring, "God, I hope the old man doesn't die."

Palin's nomination and subsequent popularity represent a deeper problem in American politics. Only in government is down-home, rural wisdom revered. In all other fields, we expect job candidates to be well-informed, experienced, and talented. More than anything, we expect them to be intelligent and capable. While Obama falls short on experience, he is certainly bright and articulate.

Palin, on the other hand, still

acts like she's in a beauty pageant, giving silly answers and winking at the camera.

Palin's defenders will frequently invoke two responses to her critics. They will accuse men of bullying her and being sexist, or they will accuse the media of using "gotcha" tactics. Both defenses are weak and avoid the cold truth—Sarah Palin is not capable of running the country, and she should not be allowed anywhere near the White House.

Hopefully, come November, Governor Palin will be forced to fly back home to Alaska. Perhaps if she's lucky, she can snipe a few wolves on the way. And perhaps if we're lucky, we'll never hear from her again.

Jonathan Norcross '09